War, US policy toward China was a combination of geopolitical maneuvering against the Soviet Union and aspirations of unlocking its massive market for American businesses. When Richard Nixon traveled to meet Mao Zedong in 1972, few in the United States imagined that within a generation, China would be the second most powerful nation on earth and would become an unambiguous challenger to America's leading global role. Even after the 1989 Tiananmen Square massacre, US policy was focused on integrating China into the global economy and giving Beijing a place at the table of international politics. From normalization of US-China ties in 1979 through Beijing's accession to the World Trade Organization in 2001, in addition to high-level Sino-US government exchanges such as the Strategic and Economic Dialogue, Washington consistently worked to promote deeper economic and political bonds with Beijing. The US approach was perhaps best summed up by Robert Zoellick, then deputy secretary of state, who in 2005 called on China to become a "responsible stakeholder" in the global system, pointedly distinguishing between early twenty-first-century Sino-US relations and the Cold War competition between America and the Soviet Union.[25]

The early post–Cold War years saw attempts by both the Bill Clinton and George W. Bush administrations to come up with a new grand strategy for the United States. With Europe taking a backseat in US interests for the first time in two generations, Asia rapidly began to fill the vacuum. Both administrations acknowledged the unique unipolar moment following the collapse of the Soviet Union but did not yet argue that Asia would become the cockpit of international relations. However, by the time Clinton left office, tensions were already appearing in Sino-US relations that would lead to reconsiderations of American strategy in the region.

Reflecting the central role of military capability in maintaining America's presence in Asia, the Department of Defense in 1998 issued a US Security Strategy for the East Asia–Pacific Region, which remained until 2019 the only formally published US government strategy for the Indo-Pacific region. Coming as it did when the full extent of the